Your Marriage Has a Third

What The Phone-Based Adulthood is Doing to Love and Sex

BAYA VOCE

MAR 10, 2026

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It’s 10:17 p.m and the house is finally still.

One partner is already in bed, body angled in that small, wordless way that signals come here. It isn’t necessarily sexual; it’s the end-of-the-day bid for contact after you’ve been “adulting” all day for everyone else.

The other partner slides in beside them and, without a second thought… phone out, face lit, thumb moving. A last email check. A news scan. A “real quick” look at Instagram that turns into ten minutes because the feed is designed to feel like it might deliver something important if you keep going.

Nothing dramatic happens; no yelling, slamming doors, or single, cinematic rejection that would justify a fight. But the body registers it anyway.

The partner who “turned toward” feels something so small and familiar, it’s almost embarrassing to name. A faint drop in the chest, a tightening behind the ribs. A private recalibration: I guess we’re not doing that tonight.

They might not say anything because it will sound petty and they’re exhausted. I don’t have the energy to start an argument this late, they might think. And what does it say about me that I “need attention” at 10:17 p.m. when everyone is fried, and life is relentless, and, honestly, it’s just a phone? So they swallow it, start their own numbing scroll, roll over, or ask a logistical question so the emotional request stays hidden inside something respectable.

The partner on the phone doesn’t think they are abandoning anyone. They experience themselves as decompressing; just checking one last thing, turning their brain off, and finding relief after a day of meetings, parenting, vigilance.

Two understandable experiences. One tiny injury.

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Now imagine you meet a couple, and they tell you, casually, that every night a third person joins them in bed. Someone who interrupts eye contact, pulls attention away when you’re in the middle of talking, rewards withdrawal with novelty, and trains you to leave whenever intimacy starts to feel demanding. Would we call that “decompression”?

There’s no affair or secret texting. The third is social media, Slack, sports alerts, group chats, online outrage. Other people’s lives, bodies, jokes,

takes — an infinite social room you can enter without the friction of an actual relationship.

As a couples practitioner, I see what smartphones are doing to relationships in my practice every day. A relationship rarely dies from one catastrophic betrayal, and most of the couples I see aren't destroyed by a single event. They erode through tiny departures that are too frequent to ignore, in which one partner's attention leaves the room while their body is still there. The phone is unusually good at producing this kind of erosion. It hides inside the banal, outwardly mimicking togetherness while, in reality, creating distance. In an intimate relationship, this subtle, reflexive pattern of divided attention creates thousands of small injuries that accumulate over time, eroding trust and collapsing erotic potential and emotional safety.

Attention has become a scarce resource. Where it goes, how reliably it returns, and whether your partner can find you in the fleeting yet important micro-moments that add up to connection can determine whether your relationship thrives long term.

Attention Begets (and Betrays) Intimacy

As Jonathan Haidt, Johann Hari, and Kaitlyn Regehr have argued, smartphones are reshaping our attention. This shows up in the most intimate places of ordinary life, affecting our closest relationships with our partners, kids, friends, and family members.

Intimacy researchers have agreed since the late 1980s that the core of closeness is perceived partner responsiveness; the feeling that your partner sees and understands you, and cares about what you're going through. This intimacy is built during the mundane, forgettable moments around the house, in the car, and between meals. Decades of subsequent research have confirmed that perceived responsiveness reliably predicts relationship satisfaction, emotional intimacy, and even physical affection.

In a longitudinal study published by relationship psychologist John Gottman, couples who stayed together over the six years of the study responded to each other's "bids for connection" (small, everyday attempts to engage) about 86% of the time. Couples who divorced responded only about 33% of the time. The researchers concluded that "The mundane and often fleeting moments that a couple experiences in their everyday lives may contribute to the health or deterioration of a relationship by serving as a foundation to major couple events such as conflict discussions and caring days." In other words, couples' daily investment of attention in the ordinary moments can make the difference between lasting love and its collapse.

Relationships erode through tiny departures in which one partner's attention leaves the room while their body is still there. The phone is unusually good at producing this kind of erosion.

But modern life has made sustained attention difficult to produce. The cognitive load on adults — particularly partnered adults with children — is historically unusual. Dual-income households, information saturation, decision fatigue, and the ambient hum of perpetual availability create a chronic mental overload on a scale that previous generations didn't face. On top of the cognitive weight, there's the emotional labor of managing children's feelings, maintaining competence at work, navigating extended family dynamics, and tracking the logistics of a shared life. By the time both partners land in bed at 10 p.m., their attentional budget is depleted.

Then there's proximity. Many of us carry our phones into the places where intimacy used to live — the first minutes after waking, the walk from the car to the front door, the last stretch before sleep. A 2025 YouGov survey found that most Americans keep their phone on the bed or directly beside it at night, with younger adults more likely to sleep with the device on the mattress itself. The phone co-opts the space between partners, at the precise moments when connection used to have the best chance of happening.

All of this adds up to what we might call “phone-based adulthood,” a structural problem where cognitive saturation meets the most frictionless, ever-present relief valve ever engineered. Most people aren’t ignoring their partners out of cruelty or indifference; they’re doing it inadvertently, almost subconsciously. The phone offers stimulation, relief, and the feeling of being somewhere else. For an exhausted adult, that’s a compelling proposition. But it slowly and quietly eats away at their relationship.

Share

The Phone-Based Adulthood

Recently, a friend of mine was sitting with his eight-year-old son, Ari, and Ari’s step-mom. She was talking to Ari, and he was half paying attention, half reading a book. My friend said, “Ari, pay attention when she’s talking.” Ari put the book down. Then my friend asked, “Was that kind?” Ari said, “No.” My friend invited him to apologize, and he did.

Something about the interaction sat wrong with my friend — it left him feeling hypocritical. The next day, he apologized to his son too, because he knows his attention is in more than one place sometimes. Then he asked Ari, “Do you ever feel like I’m distracted when we’re hanging out?” Ari nonchalantly said, “Yeah, you’re always on your phone, and it makes me feel like you don’t want to talk to me.”

My friend recoiled at the truth of this. His kid just named his hurt in a single sentence, and did it without resentment.

Adults rarely speak like this. The person who feels their partner’s attention drift to the phone doesn’t usually say, It makes me feel like you don’t want to talk to me. They often say nothing, start a fight about something else, or pick up their own phone and match the distance, but the pain is the same. The phone has trained and normalized attention-splitting, and the people closest to us — children and partners alike — are left vying for the attention of someone who is right there and somehow not.

The phone co-opts the space between partners, at the precise moments when connection used to have the best chance of happening.

Availability is not a grand romantic stance, but a repeated micro-behavior. It's bringing your eyes up when your partner starts talking; the split-second pause before you reach for your phone; the choice to stay in the room after an awkward interaction instead of going away (literally or figuratively). But the phone-based adulthood makes this harder in two key ways:

First, it normalizes chronic partial presence. Many people now live in an "open tab" state of continuous partial attention, a term coined by sociologist Linda Stone. With a smartphone always in reach, one's attention is constantly split between the room they're in and the world inside the device.

Second, it creates an always-available exit from normal interpersonal friction. In relationships, friction is a necessary ingredient that allows you the opportunity to either deepen your connection or detach. Smartphones make detachment easy and instant, undercutting one of the main growth mechanisms for the relationship.

These two habitual patterns are behind more relationship strain than most couples recognize. A partner who is physically beside you but mentally gone, over and over, in the moments that used to be yours together — those small departures accumulate and create distance.

Leave a comment

What I See Clinically

In my private practice, relationship problems that stem from phone-based adulthood show up in a few specific, recognizable ways, couple after couple.

Attention is the New Fidelity

Traditional infidelity is obvious. Someone invests secrecy, time, erotic energy, and emotional intimacy outside the partnership.

Attention infidelity is harder to identify because it's socially sanctioned and functionally invisible. It doesn't look like "choosing someone else"; it's "checking something," "unwinding," "being informed," "responding quickly for work." It looks like "I'm listening, keep talking." But what many partners experience is I cannot access you, or you don't care.

Studies consistently link partner phone use during interactions, or "phubbing" (phone + snubbing), with lower relationship satisfaction, in part through feeling excluded and less responded to.

What intimate relationships actually need (and healthy relationships have) is not constant togetherness, but reliable access. Couples can weather enormous stress, distance, and conflict, as long as both people trust that the other is fundamentally reachable. The phone disrupts precisely this.

In a healthy relationship, the hard parts of the day get processed together, not side-by-side in silence. When the phone becomes the regulator for both nervous systems, the relationship becomes the place you rest from, not the place you recover in.

Micro-Withdrawal Replaces Overt Withdrawal

What keeps couples connected through the normal friction of life is their confidence that their bids for connection will be received. When one partner consistently withdraws by, for instance, leaving the room and refusing to engage, it undermines this essential faith.

Phone withdrawal is micro-withdrawal. Because it's socially acceptable, some people might not even see it as impolite. It's the downward glance your partner makes in the middle of your sentence, the half "mmhmm" while reading, or the reflexive reach for the phone after a question that's just a little too vulnerable.

Because it’s ambiguous (as opposed to, say, leaving a room and slamming the door), partners second-guess themselves. Am I overly sensitive? Am I controlling? Should I let them decompress? It’s been a hard day; they should be able to decompress. So they don’t bring it up.

Over time, micro-withdrawal trains both partners: The one who turns toward the other learns to stop turning, and the one who turns away learns that withdrawal is painless, unchallenged, and easy. Then couples show up in therapy saying, “We’re just not as close as we used to be.” They didn’t consciously choose distance, but it accumulated through tiny, seemingly inconsequential moments of half-presence that became a regular state.

Conflict Avoidance, Optimized

Sometimes after a tense exchange, one partner picks up their phone to “calm down.” The other experiences abandonment and escalates. The scroller feels criticized and doubles down on the frictionless exit. This is called the pursuer-distancer cycle — one of the most common dynamics in couples therapy. (Phones don’t create this cycle, but they accelerate it.)

In my office, it often looks like this:

> A couple had a tiny argument about coming home late, say. One partner says, “Can we talk about what just happened?” The other says, “I can’t do this right now,” and reaches for the phone out of instinct. One thumb flick: a news headline, a reel, an endless feed.
>
> The partner who wanted to talk starts to put two and two together. You have energy for strangers and scrolling, but you don’t have energy for me.
>
> “Are you seriously doing this?” comes out sharper than intended. Now the scroller feels attacked, and within minutes, they’re arguing about the phone itself but the real pain happened when one person made a bid (“can we talk about this”) and the other shut down.

In relationships that handle conflict well, tension happens, people misunderstand each other, and by grappling with nervous system regulation, wounds, and internal dramas together, the couple finds their way through. The repair doesn't have to be graceful; it just has to happen.

The phone short-circuits that repair rhythm by giving the distancer on-demand relief and the pursuer fuel to monitor and escalate. Because the device is always within arm's reach, conflict doesn't get the natural cooldown it used to when there was less stimulus available.

Erotic Friction

The mechanics of desire depend on presence. Erotic connection requires attention bandwidth and the sense that your partner is there with their attention turned toward you.

When one or both partners are habitually half absent, scrolling before bed or checking notifications when something could start to build between you, initiation can feel riskier than the ordinary vulnerability of wanting someone. So you hesitate or try, and it may not land because your partner isn't present enough to register the bid. Over time, rejection becomes more likely, and rejection in long-term love rarely stays confined to sex — it spills into identity. Am I wanted? Am I chosen? Am I still compelling to you?

Then couples do what people always do when a topic carries shame: they stop talking about it and avoid initiating. They protect themselves. The bedroom becomes less a place for intimacy and more a reminder of the distance: two people side-by-side, absorbed in their screens while the physical closeness makes the emotional gap feel worse.

What Actually Helps: Attention Agreements

When couples try to solve the phone/attention problem with declarations (e.g. we should be more present), it often doesn't work. Without clear agreements, "being present" becomes a vague standard that either

partner can hold over the other. Moral pressure activates defensiveness, and defensiveness kills intimacy.

Instead, it helps to treat attention as a shared resource with rules, boundaries, and repair mechanisms, similar to how couples often treat money. Households have a better chance at functioning well when partners have clear agreements around how they make, save, and spend money. Attention requires the same intentional approach.

Here are three simple things you and your partner can do to create containment with phone usage and preserve (or restore) your connection to each other.[1]

1) Build Predictable Availability (Instead of Chasing "Device-Free" Purity)

You don't have to ban phones; you just need to focus attention during key windows.

Sit down with your partner and pick a few zones/periods of concerted, distraction-free time and make them reliable. For most couples, the highest-leverage ones are the first stretch after reunions (e.g., waking up and coming home from work) and the last stretch before sleep. If your relationship currently includes "parallel scrolling in bed," start there. Talk to your partner about which area would make the biggest difference, and start with one. For instance, "After we come home from work, let's take 30 minutes to do our own thing and decompress, and then spend the next hour together with our phones in another room."

2) Tell Your Partner When You're Leaving and When You'll be Back

Sometimes people get overloaded and someone will check out — either intentionally or unintentionally — by picking up their phone. That's expected and normal. Relationships survive better if withdrawal has a predictable return.

When you're each regulated, and before you're in the heat of the moment, make an agreement that when one of you needs to check out, you'll name it and put a time limit on it. That's it. The simple ritual of telling your partner you're going and when you'll be back makes all the difference, instead of leaving them wondering where you went while you scroll.

A return practice can be short: "I'm going to look at my phone for ten minutes to reset. Then I'm back, and I'd love to connect with you." Then keep your commitment and actually come back within the time you identified.

3) Treat the Phone as a Symptom Before You Treat it as the Villain

If your partner is scrolling compulsively at night, the instinct is to make the phone the problem. Couples who only fight about the phone miss the pain underneath. Couples who address the pain often see the phone use drop because they're able to solve the actual issue.

This can sound like, "I've noticed that when we're both on our phones at night, I feel more alone than I want to. Can we talk about that?" Lead with your own experience, not your theory about theirs.

If you don't decide where your attention goes, Meta, Apple, and OpenAI will decide for you. The attention economy doesn't need your relationship to fail; it just needs your partner to be unavailable, a hundred times a day, forever.

If your relationship feels harder than it should, if you feel lonely next to someone you love, or if you keep having the same fight about attention that starts from almost nothing, the explanation might be more structural than personal. Your relationship has a third.

Rather than panic, the solution is for you and your partner to acknowledge what we're all up against, and to establish some attention agreements. In my practice, couples who do this are often surprised at how quickly things shift. You can defend access to each other and reclaim the little moments of connection. It's just about being intentional when it comes to your relationship's most precious resource — your attention.

Comments:

Marc Chappe

Mar 10

Wife and I are in our 80's, and hence, had the good fortune to grow up in an analog world. We have eshewed a smart phone, but have a landline and keep a flip phone for emergencies. We have lots of books, and read aloud to each other often. We talk to each other and listen carefully.

We've been at this for nigh on 60 years.

From my perspective it's difficult to see how so many people become so ensorcelled by a device that's an attention-leech, that disengages them from others. It would seem to call for an intervention - an emergency meeting - whatever - that would wrest folks away from a device and into each other's embrace.

LIKE (45)

REPLY (4)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

This is beautiful. I imagine many will read this comment and wish they were in your shoes. It's hard to imagine the addictive quality of phones and tech distractions. Thank you for your words.

LIKE (8)

REPLY

SHARE

Domestic Blitz

Mar 10

Marc, your natural wisdom and ease are enviable for those in my cohort of marriage (I'm in my 30s). The phone is such a temptation of distraction... My husband and I are not on social media, have deleted most of the distracting apps from our phones, but we still struggle with attention throughout the day and at night... And we're almost ludites compared to most couples I know.

It's like Ed Tech infiltrating schools, so many of us are chained to technology through jobs and our social life and it makes it so difficult to put up meaningful boundaries between the outside world of distraction and intimacy.

LIKE (8)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

Feeling this deeply!

LIKE (3)

REPLY

SHARE

Blanch Ann

Mar 10

I think you said it. You had the good fortune to grow up in a world without tech for six decades. That’s huge. Your foundations and habits had been built and laid. You didn’t have

the tech to suck your attention away in your formative growing up, or even into your parenting years.

The reason these devices suck our attention is because they were designed to do so! They are incredibly convenient. Banking, shopping, communicating, driving directions, you name it. It's all right there. We've traded so much for this convenience!

At nearly 50, I'm also very grateful that I had an analog childhood and was into my 30s before I got my first smart phone. My husband and I chose not to have a TV for the first year we were married so that we could have deeper conversations and long walks. We read books to each other too when we were first married 25 years ago.

Though the phone didn't firm me in those early years, I'll be damned if it's not trying to form me now. When they came along, we didn't know how addictive they would become!

In my house of 3 teens, we have to be very intentional about phone time. My kids don't get phones until they're driving age because we're trying to stack as many analog years as we can. But still, within the first couple of years, I've watched both of my older kids really wrestle with setting boundaries on their phones in order to prioritize academics, sports, relationships, faith, you name it.

As you said it, interventions are necessary. We have them in our house regularly.

LIKE (3)

REPLY

SHARE

Nancy Powell

Mar 11*Edited*

I grew up analog too, but have realized how additive the phone and ipad can be. I notice these patterns because I read a lot, and read newspapers and magazine articles, and a lot of substack articles, now on my iPad. My question is, reading at night is what a lot of people do....so is it substantively different that it's on a screen and not paperback? Same for the morning news. I can remember seeing my dad every day reading the paper at breakfast, half listening to the conversation around us. I used to love the mornings when my husband and I sat at the table and both reading the paper, but it is different with screens. As the author notes, "checking out" is not new, but it is easier and more insidious now. And as hard as it is for our generation to unplug, how much harder it is going to be for everyone younger.

LIKE (1)

REPLY

SHARE

na

Mar 10

Wow, fascinating read how these micro-moments have such impact.

Remember a friend who was son of a busy dad that worked really hard with high cognitive load. When the son was around 20 he told his dad a joke in the car. The father started laughing and the son started crying. Later the son realized it was because his father was present for the first time in a long time.

Being present is the highest currency in a world full of distractions.

LIKE (32)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

Wow, that's such a simple and powerful moment. Thanks for sharing.

LIKE (2)

REPLY

SHARE

Tom Sherry

Mar 10

I have a wife and a teen son. We have tried to institute a new house rule, "One thing at at time." That is, when we are all watching a show on tv, we just watch that show and not scroll

on phones or laptops. It was only after the "new rule" that I realized how distracted we had become. Changing that pattern is harder than it sounds.

LIKE (16)

REPLY (1)
SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

I LOVE this rule!

LIKE (1)

REPLY
SHARE

Nicolai Michelet

Mar 10

Great piece. Thank you. You could also argue that the phone-based adulthood is doing this to most micro moments where connection used to happen in society, like talking to strangers at the store, or at a bus stop.

LIKE (13)

REPLY (1)
SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

100%. That's absolutely right. Same experience in daily moments outside of close relationships.

LIKE (2)

REPLY

SHARE

Lucy Beney

Mar 10

Thank you for this – this is true in my experience as well. It is interesting that some young people (in early to mid twenties) are now trying to protect themselves in advance from this. I have talked with a lot who are clear that before they get into a serious relationship – let alone become parents – they want to find strategies to restrict and limit their phone use. Many have learned the hard way, feeling the disconnect with their own parents and friends.

LIKE (6)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

I'm so glad to hear this. It's almost like tobacco in a way... the previous generation didn't understand its damage... the generations coming up now understand it in a very new way.

LIKE (2)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Lucy Beney

Mar 10

Thank you so much – I'm glad to hear it too!

LIKE

REPLY
SHARE

Chris McKenna

Mar 10

Excellent writing, thank you. Reminds me of a quote from Brené Brown, during an interview with Esther Perel, "Attention is such an undervalued expression of love."

LIKE (4)

REPLY (1)
SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

I LOVE that quote. It rings so true.

LIKE (2)

REPLY
SHARE

Christina Dinur

Mar 10

I keep saying it: parental smartphone addiction is the elephant in the room in the whole discussion around kids & phones. Our actions speak louder than our words, and if we're not modeling healthy digital habits, how can we expect our kids to develop good habits?

I switched to a flip phone two years ago because relying on willpower to be more intentional around my phone use wasn't cutting it. I am here to tell you: this is easier than most people

realize, and it is so liberating. I am still a functional member of society. I organize events in my community, have children in public school, and am a freelance copywriter/editor - all without a smartphone. More and more adults in this movement are switching to dumb phones - it can be done!

LIKE (5)

REPLY

SHARE

Ruth Gaskovski

Mar 10*Edited*

"Attention is the new fidelity" - the saddest part about this excellent piece is that the advice still leaves the "third person" between the couple. The division remains, it is merely managed or reduced. As long as couples are synchronized to their devices, rather than each other, true intimacy and attention fidelity will remain elusive.

LIKE (4)

REPLY (2)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

It's so tricky, right? Because if we ask people to band their phones, it's unlikely anyone would do it... so we need to understand the small moves we can make to manage it vs take it away all together. That doesn't make it easy, though. This is a very distinct problem without a lot of easy solutions. That said, I do think that with the few simple ideas outlined here, we can do much better with our attention fidelity.

LIKE (2)

REPLY

SHARE

Christina Dinur

Mar 10

I couldn't agree more. Unfortunately, in so many well-intentioned articles like this, the solution proposed does not match the gravity of the problem. Why are we settling for only carving out a few times a day when we're not beholden to addictive technology? Why not reject addictive technology altogether, or at least explore the possibility?

Highly recommend this excellent Ted Talk from Gabriela Nguyen, an inspirational Gen Z woman who ditched both social media and her smartphone--and lived to tell the story: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tslzTC3nt_0

LIKE (1)

REPLY

SHARE

Robert Hunter

Mar 10

Ralph Nader nailed it years ago. "The modern opiate of the masses is the smart phone". Worst of all, the people who control the "smart phone" are the best psych trained people in mind control, employed to control you in way's that not obvious to you. Orwell couldn't imagine this. Edward Bernays couldn't imagine this but he would be proud of his students. This is worse than religion in the middle ages with the total mind control of the time.

LIKE (3)

REPLY

SHARE

Erik Hanson

Mar 10

Such a good quote... I wish more realized this reality:

"If you don't decide where your attention goes, Meta, Apple, and OpenAI will decide for you. The attention economy doesn't need your relationship to fail; it just needs your partner to be unavailable, a hundred times a day, forever."

If this holds true, that does not turn out well for human to human in person relationships...

What we are competing with is a real threat. I wish there were actual couples classes that focused on this topic that couples could take together, with other couples. Individuals too. This is not what my parents had to navigate... :(

LIKE (2)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

It's not what anyone has ever had to navigate so it truly is new terrain for all of us. I also want those classes!

LIKE

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Erik Hanson

Mar 23

It is so wild that we have to constantly remind ourselves that so much of what we are experiencing nobody has experienced before us. A bit hard to comprehend, IMO. Relationship maintenance might take on a new meaning with all of this.

LIKE

REPLY

SHARE

Ananisapta

Mar 10

"Many of us carry our phones into the places where intimacy used to live..." Brilliant prose! Speaking from the perspective of a successful marriage that has lasted nearly 60 years, I heartily endorse this author's perspective. And I ask you, how "smart" is it to pay what you are paying, both in money and in attention, for your gizmo? My wife and I both spend a fair amount of time in front of a desktop or laptop computer, but for phoning we have a landline and a couple of flip phones that cost around $50 on Amazon and get good service for $6 monthly. So how dumb is that?

LIKE (2)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

I love that you have a landline and flip phones that you use!

LIKE

REPLY

SHARE

Kai Teorn

Mar 10

I think there's another unhealthy dynamic here. Some people may see their partners' attempts to get through to them as controlling. "Lay down your phone when you're with me" may come through as hostility, aggression, abuse. People these days tend to see the world divided sharply into refugees and aggressors, and they may be too quick to see their partner as an aggressor when that partner tries to evict them out of their digital refuge. I am happy to see voices like this, arguing the "please give me attention" position, but I feel like there are

a lot more "my attention is mine, I'm not giving it to you unless I choose to" voices, even in committed relationships. It's a very hard knot to untie.

LIKE (1)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

I agree that it's such a tricky knot to untie. I actually created a pdf if you're interested that goes more into HOW to actually say the thing you want to say without it being an attack and really inviting someone into the conversation with you. Feel free to check it out if it seems like it could be useful for you: https://repair.bayavoce.com/lonely-next-to-you-1

LIKE (2)

REPLY

SHARE

Matthew VonStein

Mar 10

A phenomenal article. Well written, Baya.

A relationship is strengthened because of constancy. We don't have to be together at all times, but at all KINDS of times. Our socially excepted phone escapism has narrowed that constancy dramatically. In the car, after work, in bed at night. When you're stressed, when you're happy, when your annoyed. Our phones have a frictionless 'fix' for each occasion, and our relationships suffer.

Baya, thank you.

LIKE (1)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

I'm so glad this article landed for you. Thanks so much for your comment.

LIKE

REPLY

SHARE

Jennifer

Mar 10

Screen-based relating, as a Gen Xer, has been a norm my whole life.

Walking into homes, businesses, waiting rooms with a TV that's always on.

At a gas pump, as soon as you start a transaction, a screen kicks on to arrest your attention for those few moments of stillness and waiting.

If it wasn't screens, it was the radio or paper. Phones have replaced TVs, portable cassette/CD players, books, catalogs, magazines, and newspapers.

There's has been a way to check out of present company and the present moment for a long time.

LIKE (1)

REPLY (1)

SHARE

Baya Voce

Mar 10

I completely agree with what you're saying... the distraction is everywhere and it has always been everywhere. The difference with phones is that we carry them with us and they basically never leave our sides. So even though we've always had a way to distract ourselves, now the distraction possibilities are endless and live right next to many of us at all times. Thanks so much for your comment.

LIKE (1)

REPLY

SHARE

Kate of Kate Hall

Mar 10

An LLM wrote this. Disappointing. It's an important subject.

LIKE (1)

REPLY

SHARE

James Marcuzzo

Apr 3

Or do what my wife does and ignore my phone and move in anyway. Between the two, the choice is always easy. A phone is a thing and it should be treated as such